The Ten Essentials

The gear systems every outdoor adventurer should carry on every trip — no matter how short

The Ten Essentials were first compiled in the 1930s by The Mountaineers, a Seattle-based climbing organization. Originally a list of individual items, they've evolved into ten functional systems. As a Pierce County search and rescue unit, we can tell you: these aren't suggestions. They're the difference between a minor inconvenience and a life-threatening emergency.

WHY IT MATTERS

The majority of people we rescue were on day hikes and didn't expect to be out overnight. A wrong turn, a twisted ankle, or unexpected weather changed everything. The Ten Essentials weigh 3-5 pounds and fit in any daypack. There is no good reason not to carry them.

1 Navigation

Topographic map and compass (know how to use them), GPS device or phone with downloaded offline maps, altimeter. Electronics fail — batteries die, screens crack, satellites lose signal. A paper map and compass always work. Before your trip, study the map and identify key landmarks, trail junctions, and water sources along your route.

SAR PRO TIP

Download the area map on your phone while you have WiFi. Turn on location services and carry a portable charger.

2 Headlamp

A headlamp (not just a flashlight — you need both hands free) with extra batteries. LED models last much longer than incandescent. Even on a day hike, you may need to navigate in darkness if your trip runs long. A headlamp also serves as an emergency signaling device at night.

SAR PRO TIP

Test your headlamp before every trip. Store it with batteries reversed or in lock mode so it doesn't turn on in your pack.

3 Sun Protection

Sunscreen (SPF 30+, reapply every 2 hours), UV-blocking sunglasses, sun hat with brim, and lip balm with SPF. UV exposure increases 4-5% with every 1,000 feet of elevation gain. Snow reflects up to 80% of UV rays. Sunburn and snow blindness can be debilitating.

SAR PRO TIP

In the Cascades, UV is intense even on overcast days. Apply sunscreen to often-missed areas: ears, back of neck, and under your chin (reflection from snow/water).

4 First Aid Kit

A comprehensive kit with: adhesive bandages, gauze pads, medical tape, antibiotic ointment, pain relievers (ibuprofen, acetaminophen), blister treatment (moleskin), tweezers, trauma shears, SAM splint, elastic wrap, antihistamines, and any personal medications. Customize for your group's medical needs.

SAR PRO TIP

Take a Wilderness First Aid course. Knowing how to use your kit matters more than what's in it. Check expiration dates every season.

5 Knife & Repair Tools

A sturdy knife or multi-tool, plus repair supplies: duct tape (wrap some around a water bottle or trekking pole to save space), cord/paracord (50 ft), safety pins, zip ties, and gear-specific items (tent pole splint, patch kit). These let you improvise solutions to equipment failures in the field.

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SAR PRO TIP
Duct tape fixes almost anything temporarily — torn rain gear, blisters (as a second skin), splints, pack straps. Carry at least 3 feet.

6 Fire Starting
Waterproof matches AND a butane lighter (carry both — redundancy matters), plus fire starters (cotton balls coated in petroleum jelly, commercial fire starters, or dryer lint). Fire provides warmth, water purification, cooking, signaling, and psychological comfort. Know how to build a fire in wet conditions — practice at home first.

SAR PRO TIP
Store fire-starting supplies in a waterproof bag or container. In the Pacific Northwest, assume everything will be wet. Carry tinder that lights when damp.

7 Emergency Shelter
An ultralight emergency bivy, space blanket, or lightweight tarp (8×10 feet minimum). Combined with extra clothing and a fire, shelter can keep you alive in surprisingly harsh conditions. Even on a day hike, an unplanned night out is always possible. Hypothermia kills more people in the backcountry than any other cause.

SAR PRO TIP
Practice setting up your emergency shelter at home. In a real emergency, you'll be cold, tired, and possibly injured — that's not the time to figure it out.

8 Extra Food
At least one full extra day's worth of food that requires no cooking: energy bars, nuts, dried fruit, jerky, peanut butter packets, chocolate. Your body burns 3,000-5,000 calories per day hiking at altitude. Keeping your energy up maintains body heat and mental clarity. Hunger impairs judgment.

SAR PRO TIP
Keep emergency food separate from your trip food so you're never tempted to eat it early. Rotate it every few months to keep it fresh.

9 Extra Water
Carry at least 1 liter more than you think you need, plus a way to treat more: pump filter, squeeze filter, chemical treatment (iodine or chlorine dioxide tablets), or UV purifier. In Pierce County's mountains, streams are plentiful but must be treated for Giardia, Cryptosporidium, and bacteria. Dehydration impairs judgment and physical ability.

SAR PRO TIP
Pre-hydrate before your hike — drink 16 oz in the hour before you start. On the trail, drink before you're thirsty. If your urine is dark, you're already dehydrated.

10 Extra Clothing
Layers for conditions significantly colder and wetter than forecast: a warm insulating layer (fleece or puffy), a waterproof/breathable rain jacket and pants, warm hat, and gloves. Avoid cotton — it loses all insulating value when wet. Use wool or synthetic materials. The old saying 'cotton kills' exists for a reason.

SAR PRO TIP
Pierce County's elevation range means you can start at 50°F at the trailhead and encounter 25°F with wind chill at the summit. Always layer for the highest point on your route.

PACK IT EVERY TIME
Keep your Ten Essentials in a dedicated bag that's always packed and ready. Before each trip, check batteries, expiration dates, and water treatment supplies. Adjust clothing for the season but never skip the fundamentals. These 3-5 extra pounds could save your life.